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PM wants to stop importing lithium since India has deposits. Mining reforms are happening apace. For example, copper mines now have permission to extract more materials from waste. We aim to reduce the clearance time to six months and start mines quickly.



Economists say this is India's new 1991 moment—a big challenge and opportunity. What reforms should be prioritised?

Our government is undertaking many reforms. But I have one grievance: the focus is too urban-centric

and Delhi-Mumbai-centric. I come from a village. Agriculture and allied sectors contribute only 18% to GDP, industry 24%, and services about 54-56%. Until agriculture productivity increases and its GDP share rises to 22%, we cannot achieve the desired economic growth. Focus must be on agriculture, rural, tribal areas, water, land, forest, and animals. Rural India needs more attention. Most discussions focus on Delhi-Mumbai, but India's foundation—agriculture and rural sectors—is not discussed as much. Without strengthening that, our achievements

will be incomplete.

One of the biggest issues is water. When I was Water Resources Minister, there were 23 disputes between states. For example, water meant for India was flowing to Pakistan, while Haryana and Punjab fought over water. I called the chief ministers and said, 'This water is your right going elsewhere; why fight among yourselves?' I resolved 17 disputes.

Our government made 49 river connectivity projects, and I prepared their project reports. For example, Ken-Betwa project brings water to drought-affected

Bundelkhand. I went to Telangana-Andhra Pradesh and approved ₹60,000 crore for Polavaram project. About 1,300 TMC of Godavari water was going to sea. Our plan diverts Godavari water to Krishna, Krishna to Pennar, Pennar to Cauvery, and Cauvery to Tamil Nadu, resolving water issues in Tamil Nadu and Karnataka.

If water comes with drip irrigation and grafting techniques, agriculture growth will triple. Surplus foodgrains will be used for ethanol production from maize and broken rice. If ₹10 lakh crore of our ₹22 lakh crore economy is diverted to agriculture, it will change.

I am not just a politician; I work in agriculture; roads are my second priority. I took farmers to Malaysia and Spain where one acre produces 25-30 tonnes of oranges, while our Nagpur oranges yield only 3 tonnes. If we bring that technology, we can improve. Israel's kibbutz system uses computers to manage water in air-conditioned houses; this can be done here too.

Growth in agriculture and allied sectors is our priority. Our government has continuously supported farmers. I believe agricultural growth will contribute significantly to India's GDP growth. **BT**

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